In My Hands

By Irene Gut Opdyke

NOTE: Should be presented with a pronounced Polish accent as an elderly woman recounts her memories . . .

I was twenty, and it seemed as though half my life had been wartime. Sometimes I felt like an old woman. I had seen terrible things, and terrible things had been done to me

INTRODUCTION

Irene Gut Opdyke received international recognition for risking her life by aiding and saving Jews during the Holocaust. She was presented with the Israel Medal of Honor, Israel's highest tribute, the Vatican has given her a special commendation; and her story is part of a permanent exhibit in the United States Holocaust Memorial Museum in Washington, D.C. Ms. Opdyke began to share her story only recently -- after hearing the Holocaust denounced as a hoax or propaganda. She now travels the country, speaking to groups large and small, old and young.. This is her story . . . In My Hands by Irene Gut Opdyke

Often—such as when a German officer made some rude, suggestive comment, or when I saw a child in the street who looked particularly thin and hungry—often I felt a great welling up of hatred and rebellion. It was not right, what I had seen and what had been done to me, and what I saw around me every day. In God's name, it was not right! And yet I was relatively safe. I was well fed. I had my sister Janina with me. I knew that most people were not as well of as I was. If I felt so much anger and outrage, what must other people not so fortunate be feeling? Surely, the evil being done in my country must be a poison that would ruin the soil, tarnish the air, and foul the water. Sometimes, when I thought of the amount of hatred dwelling in Poland, I was surprised to see that the grass was still green, that the trees still flourished their leaves against a blue sky.

And yet they did. It is a terrible irony of was, that nature itself does not rebel when man turns against his brother. I have seen nightmares take place on beautiful spring days. The birds can hop from one branch to another, tipping their heads and honing their small beaks against the bark while a child dies in the mud below.

One Sunday in July we found our friend Helen and her mother in a state of barely controlled hysteria. They had heard a rumor that a large number of Jews from the *Arbeitslagers* and from surround areas had been rounded up by the SS and were being held in a nearby village. Helen begged us to go with her, to see if she could find her husband Henry among them.

Janina and I did not have to confer. The four of us hitched a ride on a farmer's wagon and were soon in town, at the bus station. There were dozens of people waiting for the same bus, and from the bits and pieces of overheard conversation, we knew that most of them were on the same fearful errand.

As we waited in the sun for our bus, rumor snuck like a pickpocket through the crowd, stealing the hope from people's hearts. At first, only isolated words stood out against the general murmur: Camps. Disappeared. All. Death squads. Then we heard whole phrases: Burned the synagogue. Shot the men. Orders from Berlin.

All of us in that crowd were fearful of what lay ahead, and yet when the bus finally came wheezing and grinding its gears down the street, we rushed forward as one body. The bus filled. It pulled away. We were all on it.

There was very little tlak as the bus made its way to our destination. There was nothing to say. When we arrived, we climbed down onto the hot pavement, and as if by some secret signal, like a flock of sparrows wheeling away across a church square, we all moved in one direction.

It was in the marketplace. The whole square had been fenced off. Behind the barbed wire stood hundreds of people whose yellow stars marked them as Jews. Trucks were unloading scores more, and as each man, woman, or child jumped down, bewildered and

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frightened, the black-uniformed SS men sorted them roughly: women and children one way, old men another, young men toward another mass of trucks. Outside the fence, friends and family members pressed against the wire, calling out names , crowding for a glimpse of a loved one.

Suddenly, several of the guards strode toward the fence, shouting at the crowd. "*Raus! Raus verfluchte Schweine*!" One of them slung the gun off his shoulder and began shooting into the air.

There were screams on our side of the wire, and people stumbled into one another. Some would not be chased away, but kept pressing forward. The man with the gun leveled it at us, and we broke in panic. We were all running, but when I heard Janina cry, I turned to help her.

"I've twisted my ankle!" she hasped, struggling to her feet.

Helen and I took her arms, and the four of us dodged through the crowd to a row of building lining the square. We slipped down an alley, and I found a door that stood ajar. Putting my shoulder to it, I shoved it wide, and we all hurried inside.

It was a house. It was someone's house, but no one lived there now: furniture was broken, scattered across the floor. Broken dishes and glassware lay in piles, and dark squares on the wallpaper showed where pictures and paintings had been taken down.

"This is a Jewish home," Helen said, turning around and around amid the wreckage. "This house has been raided."

We heard more shouts and pounding footsteps on the street outside. Without speaking, we ran up the stairs and into a front bedroom. Janina hobbled to a window, and stood with her back to the wall so she could peek out sideways. We all did the same. We did not speak, but our hard breathing was loud in the empty room.

Below in the marketplace, the SS men had lined up facing the Jews, their guns gleaming in the sun. "*Raus, Schweinhundjude! Schnell! Schnell!*" Out Jewish pigs! Fast! Fast!

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The gates were dragged open, and the Jewish prisoners were forced out through a gauntlet, while the guards beat at them with their rifle butts. And old man, tottering with a cane was not fast enough, and a guard shot him on the spot. In vain women tried to protect their small children from blows, men tried to shield their old fathers. But every time someone stumbled and fell under the beatings, shots rang out. The street was paved with bodies, and still the Jews were forced to march out over them.

We watched this from our windows in a paralysis of horror. We could do nothing but watch. We could not even pull back from the glass to keep hidden. An old rabbi carrying the Torah stopped to help a young woman with a shrieking toddler, and all three were shot. A graybeard in a faded uniform of the Polish army form the last war limped past the guards, and he, too, was not fast enough. The sun shone down on all of them, and the dust settled in pools of blood.

By this time, the four of us were crying uncontrollably. Helen was on her knees, sobbing in her mother's arms. Janina turned her face away. But I watched, flattening myself against the window. As I pressed against the glass, I was an officer make a flinging movement with his arm, and something rose up into the sky like a fat bird. With his other hand he aimed his pistol, and the bird plummeted to the ground beside its screaming mother, and the officer shot the mother, too.

But it was not a bird. It was not a bird. It was not a bird.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Irene Gut Opdyke
ISBN: 978-0679891819
Publisher: Knopf
Date (Month/Year): April 2001

AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier - DI